

The Last Train to Somerville

Arjun had always believed that railway stations carried memories better than people did. Every station had a smell, a sound, and a feeling attached to it. Some stations smelled of wet soil after rain, some of tea and coal smoke, and some carried the silence of goodbyes that had never truly ended. The old Somerville Junction carried all of them together.

It was nearly midnight when Arjun stepped onto Platform Three with a worn leather bag resting against his shoulder. The station clock ticked loudly in the quiet air. Only a few passengers remained scattered across the benches like forgotten pieces of a larger story. A tea seller pushed his cart slowly across the platform while humming an old melody from a black-and-white movie.

Arjun had not returned to Somerville in almost ten years.

The city where he lived now was crowded with glowing buildings, fast trains, endless notifications, and conversations that rarely meant anything. Yet one letter had been enough to bring him back. The letter had arrived three days earlier without a return address. Inside it, there was only a single line written in blue ink:

“Meet me where stories began.”

No signature. No explanation.

But Arjun knew exactly who had written it.

Meera.

The memory of her name still moved through his mind like music from another room. They had grown up together in Somerville, spending long evenings near the railway tracks, counting passing trains and inventing stories about the strangers sitting inside them. Back then, life had felt endless.

But life changed quietly.

Arjun left Somerville after receiving a scholarship in another city. Meera stayed behind to care for her father after he became ill. Calls slowly became shorter. Messages turned into occasional birthday

wishes. And then, one day, there was simply silence.

The distant horn of a train interrupted his thoughts.

The last train to Somerville arrived slowly, its headlights cutting through the darkness like two tired eyes. Arjun climbed into an almost empty compartment and sat beside the window. The train moved forward with a heavy metallic rhythm that sounded strangely comforting.

Outside, the city lights disappeared one by one.

Hours passed.

At around two in the morning, the train stopped unexpectedly in the middle of nowhere. Passengers looked around in confusion. Rain began falling against the windows in soft, steady waves.

An old man sitting across from Arjun smiled gently.

“Strange how life pauses without warning,” he said.

Arjun nodded politely.

“You seem like someone carrying unfinished conversations,” the old man continued.

The sentence struck deeper than Arjun expected.

Before he could respond, the old man pointed toward the rain outside. “People think time moves like a train. Straight. Fast. Never returning. But memories move differently. They wait for us in places we avoid.”

The train started again moments later, but the old man closed his eyes and said nothing more.

By dawn, Somerville appeared through the fog.

The town looked smaller than Arjun remembered. The paint on the station walls had faded. The bookstore near the entrance was gone. Even the giant banyan tree outside seemed older, its branches hanging lower toward the ground.

Yet something about the town remained unchanged.

He walked slowly through familiar streets until he reached the old riverside café where he and Meera used to spend their evenings. The wooden signboard still hung crookedly above the entrance.

And there she was.

Meera sat near the window with a book resting in her hands.

For a moment, neither of them moved.

Time folded silently between them.

Then she smiled.

“You still arrive late,” she said softly.

Arjun laughed nervously. “And you still start conversations like no time has passed.”

They sat together for hours.

At first, the conversation moved carefully, like two strangers testing the strength of thin ice. But gradually, old comfort returned. They spoke about childhood memories, missed opportunities, and the strange loneliness of adulthood.

Meera had become a teacher at the local school. Arjun worked as a designer in the city. Both had achieved the lives they once dreamed about.

Yet neither sounded fully happy.

“There’s something strange about growing up,” Meera said while stirring her tea. “You spend years chasing success, and then suddenly you miss the version of yourself that had nothing.”

Arjun looked outside toward the river.

“I think I spent too much time moving forward,” he admitted. “I forgot to look back.”

Meera remained silent for a moment before reaching into her bag.

She placed a small notebook on the table.

“You left this behind years ago,” she said.

Arjun opened it slowly.

Inside were dozens of unfinished stories they had written together as teenagers. Some pages contained sketches of imaginary cities. Others had lists of dreams they once planned to achieve.

One page simply read:

“One day, we’ll travel everywhere, but we’ll always return here.”

Arjun stared at the sentence quietly.

“Why did you write to me now?” he finally asked.

Meera smiled faintly.

“Because I realized something,” she said. “Life keeps giving us temporary things. Jobs. Cities. Money. Recognition. But very few people know our real story from the beginning.”

Outside, sunlight slowly spread across the river.

For the first time in years, Arjun felt still.

The day passed quickly.

They walked through old streets, visited their school, and even sat beside the abandoned railway tracks where they once spent entire summers watching trains disappear into the horizon.

As evening approached, Arjun knew he had to return to the city.

The thought suddenly felt heavier than expected.

At the station, the platform buzzed softly with evening travelers. The same tea seller from the night before walked past them carrying steaming cups.

Meera looked at Arjun carefully.

“So,” she asked, “will another ten years pass before you return?”

Arjun looked toward the train waiting at the platform.

For years, he had believed life was about reaching the next destination as quickly as possible. But standing there beside Meera, he understood something he had ignored for too long:

Some places are not meant to be left behind forever.

He smiled.

“Not this time,” he said.

The train whistle echoed through the station.

But for the first time in years, Arjun did not feel like he was leaving something behind.

Instead, it felt as though he had finally found his way back.